

Identity Verification Guidelines

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This guidance includes information from the Cabinet Office and Government Digital Service guidance on identity verification. The latest version of this guidance is available here:

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/identity-proofing-and-verification-of-an-individual/identity-proofing-and-verification-of-an-individual#strength>

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Scope

This document provides some brief guidelines on identity verification. It covers verification in any situation; over the phone, in person, digitally, or via email, by post or face-to-face

Identity verification is important whenever you are required to ensure that the person you are talking or meeting with is who they say they are. This could be when dealing with parents or new staff, volunteers or governors, contractors, police or any other third-parties.

It is especially important to know who you are talking to when discussing personal data relating to that individual or a child. Check our guidance on Parental Responsibility for more information.

Overview

This guidance includes information from the Cabinet Office and Government Digital Service guidance on identity verification.

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/identity-proofing-and-verification-of-an-individual/identity-proofing-and-verification-of-an-individual#strength>

This guidance provides a detailed scoring mechanism for identity validation within a five-stage procedure :

- get evidence of the claimed identity
- check the evidence is genuine or valid
- check the claimed identity has existed over time
- check if the claimed identity is at high risk of identity fraud
- check that the identity belongs to the person who's claiming it

Following which it is possible to build an identity profile based on the level of confidence reached in each of these areas, often using multiple validation points.

Whilst these practices are very useful in certain circumstances, for example when validating a DBS check for a prospective employee, sometimes it is necessary (for example on a phone call, or in an email) to identify someone using a much quicker process.

In that situation, here are some quick approaches to take. However, bear in mind that as the sensitivity of the topic in question increases, greater efforts should be made to assure that the person's identity has been verified, that (where necessary) they have parental

responsibility and, that the communication protocols meet security and acceptable use guidelines.

Approach 1. Confirmation of existing data.

Ask a question, or validate information that is visible on the MIS system. In order for this to be 100% validated, there is an assumption that ID documents were checked and verified when the student was registered at the school.

Questions might be related to the home address, or some other information known to the school and the parent. It could be, in relation to non-sensitive data, ensuring that the email or phone number matches that on the system (evidence of the claimed identity).

In other circumstances you may wish to query the person about data that you hold. For example, how much they last paid into the school parent account to top up lunch money (activity check).

In an ideal world there might be a passphrase stored (chosen and only known by the parent/student) that could be looked-up on the system and confirmed.

Approach 2. Confirmation of new data.

This is where deeper confirmation is required.

Follow step 1 and ask them to confirm their mobile number (evidence of the claimed identity)

Then send a text to that number with a code or password (different each time) for knowledge-based verification.

Users can wait on the phone or call back when they have the code. In extreme cases a code could be sent to the home address in the post and only when there is confirmation through that code can any business be conducted.

Get evidence of the claimed identity

Some pieces of evidence are 'stronger' than others, which means they will be harder to:

- forge (when an existing piece of evidence is changed to make it look like it belongs to someone else)
- counterfeit (when a piece of evidence is created from scratch)

You can check how strong a piece of evidence is by finding out:

- what security features are on it (for example a hologram or an electronic chip)
- what information it has
- how the person proved their identity to get the evidence

This is also known as a 'strength' check.

The stronger the evidence is, the higher its score will be. The highest score you can get for this part of the identity checking process is 4.

You must check and score one piece of evidence at a time. The evidence can be physical or digital.

To get evidence of a claimed identity, you can either:

- ask the person to provide evidence themselves, like a document (such as a passport) or account details (which they can show by giving you something like a bill or an account number)
- find some evidence of their identity yourself, for example by checking a database

The identity is sometimes shown as a synonym on different pieces of evidence. For example, it might say the person's name is Samantha on their passport, but Sam on their bank card. You can usually accept a synonym unless you need to know the claimed identity's 'official name' (this is the name on any official documents they have, such as their passport).

The names might be different on different pieces of evidence. For example, someone's surname might have changed because they got married. If the names are different, you might need to collect other pieces of evidence or do other checks to make sure all the evidence belongs to the same person.

Sometimes other information might be different on different pieces of evidence. These are mistakes known as 'transposition errors'.

This can happen with:

- names that have multiple parts, for example, 'Anna-Marie Jane' might appear as 'Anna Marie-Jane'
- days and months in dates, for example, '08.10.1978' might appear as '10.08.1978'
- centuries in dates, for example '1998' might appear as '1898'
- addresses, for example 'Flat 1a, 29 Acacia Road' might appear as 'Flat 29a Acacia Road'

These mistakes will not usually affect how you do this part of the identity checking process, but not that easy to do over the phone and are more about initial ID checks.

Score 1

The evidence will have a score of 1 if it contains at least 2 of the following pieces of information:

- the claimed identity's name
- the claimed identity's date of birth
- the claimed identity's place of birth
- the claimed identity's address
- the claimed identity's biometric information (these are measurements of biological or behavioural characteristics, like an iris or fingerprint)
- a photo of the claimed identity
- a reference number

The evidence should come from an organisation that you know will:

- check the person's identity when they issue the evidence
- make sure its process for issuing the evidence will not be misused by anyone associated with the organisation

Some examples of evidence that will have a score of 1 include an email, PDF or letter from a local authority.

You may not be able to thoroughly check the validity of evidence that has a score of 1.

Score 2

The evidence will have a score of 2 if it has everything it needs to get a score of 1 and it includes information that's unique to either:

- the identity
- that piece of evidence
- If the evidence includes a name, it must also show the person's full name instead of any pseudonyms, aliases or nicknames.

If the evidence is a physical document, it must be protected by physical security features. These features will stop it from being reproduced without specialist knowledge or information.

If the evidence includes digital information, it must either be protected by:

- cryptographic security features that correctly identify the person or organisation that issued it

- processes that make sure only authorised users can create, update and access it

Some examples of evidence that have a score of 2 include:

- a firearm certificate
- a Home Office travel document (convention travel document, stateless person's document, one-way document or certificate of travel)
- a birth or adoption certificate
- an older person's bus pass
- an education certificate from a regulated and recognised educational institution (such as an NVQ, SQA, GCSE, A level or degree certificate)
- a rental or purchase agreement for a residential property
- a proof of age card recognised under the Proof of Age Standards Scheme (PASS)
- a Freedom Pass
- a marriage or civil partnership certificate
- a building, contents or vehicle insurance policy
- a gas or electric account
- a 'substantial' electronic identity from a notified eIDAS scheme

Score 3

The evidence will have a score of 3 if it has everything it needs to get a score of 2 and:

- it includes information that's unique to both the identity and that piece of evidence
- the organisation that issued the evidence made sure it was received by the same person who applied for it
- the organisation that issued the evidence checked the person's identity in a way that follows the Money Laundering Regulations 2017

It must also:

- show the person's official name instead of their initials or synonyms, for example, 'Julian' instead of 'Jules' (if the evidence includes a name)
- be protected by physical security features that stop it from being reproduced without specialist equipment (if the evidence is a physical document)

The evidence must also include one of the following:

- a photo of the person
- biometric information that uses cryptographic security features to protect its integrity
- cryptographic security features that can be used to identify the person who owns the evidence (this includes evidence with cryptographic chips and digital accounts that are protected by cryptographic methods)

Some examples of evidence that will have a score of 3 include:

- passports that meet the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO) specifications for machine-readable travel documents
- identity cards from an EU or European Economic Area (EEA) country that follow the Council Regulation (EC) No 2252/2004 standards
- UK photocard driving licences
- EU or EEA driving licences that follow the European Directive 2006/126/EC

- a Northern Ireland electoral identity card
- a US passport card
- a bank, building society or credit union current account (which the claimed identity can show by giving you a bank card)
- a student loan account
- a credit account
- a mortgage account (including buy to let mortgage accounts)
- a digital tachograph driver smart card
- an armed forces identity card
- proof of age card recognised under PASS with a unique reference number
- a loan account (including hire purchase accounts)
- a 'high' electronic identity from a notified eIDAS scheme

Score 4

The evidence will have a score of 4 if it has everything it needs to get a score of 3 and:

- it includes biometric information
- all digital information (including biometric information) is protected by cryptographic security features
- the cryptographic security features can prove which organisation issued the evidence
- the organisation that issued the evidence proved the person's identity by comparing and matching the person to an image of the claimed identity from an authoritative source

Some examples of evidence that will have a score of 4 include:

- biometric passports that meet the ICAO specifications for e-passports
- identity cards from an EU or EEA country that follow the Council Regulation (EC) No 2252/2004 standards and contain biometric information
- a UK biometric residence permit

Check the evidence is genuine or valid

To make sure you only accept a piece of evidence that's real, you can check if it:

- is genuine (not forged or counterfeit)
- is valid (this means you can find records that show the piece of evidence has been issued)
- has not expired
- has not been cancelled or reported as lost or stolen

This is also known as a 'validity' check.

You can check the evidence in person or remotely.

The highest score you can get for this part of the identity checking process is 4.

Only physical pieces of evidence can have a score of 1. A digital piece of evidence that includes data from an authoritative source will have at least a score of 2.

Score 1

The evidence will have a score of 1 if the physical features of the evidence appear to be genuine.

They'll appear to be genuine if the person checking the evidence can confirm:

- they're checking an original, certified copy or scan of the evidence
- there are no errors on the evidence, like wrong paper type, spelling mistakes, irregular use of fonts or missing pages
- the details, layout or alignment of the evidence look the way they should
- any logos look the way they should
- any references to information are the same across the evidence (for example if the body text of a letter references an address, this should match the address shown at the top of the letter)

Score 2

The evidence will have a score of 2 if you make sure it has not expired and do one of the following:

- confirm the evidence is valid
- confirm the visible security features are genuine (these are security features that can be seen without using specialist light sources)
- confirm the ultraviolet (UV) or infrared (IR) security features are genuine

Confirm the evidence is valid

The person or system doing the check can confirm the evidence is valid by making sure the details on it match those held by an authoritative source.

Confirm the visible security features are genuine

The person or system doing the check will need to make sure:

- the original evidence has been shown (this could be in person or remotely, for example by using an app)
- they do not accept scans, photos uploaded by a user, or photocopies of the evidence (this is because it can be difficult to tell if these are forgeries or counterfeits)
- the evidence was shared with the person or system in a way that protects it from being tampered with (for example it could be sent by secure delivery)
- the evidence (or the image or video of the evidence) is clear enough to be able to examine its security features

They should check this using non-specialist light sources such as natural sunlight, indoor lights or desk lamps.

The person or system will need to use official templates to check any of the following features on the evidence look the way they should:

- background printing
- fonts and alignment
- holograms and positioning
- the way it's been laminated
- designs printed with optical variable ink (and check they look the way they should at certain angles)
- the format of any 'compound identifiers', such as a DVLA driver number or a machine-readable zone (MRZ)
- the position of any photographs on the evidence (they should not have been replaced or edited)

Some places where you can find official templates are:

- the Public Register of Authentic travel and identity Documents Online (PRADO)
- the EU and EEA driving licence handbook
- EdisonTD

If the evidence is being checked by a person, they must:

- be trained in how to detect false documents by a specialist trainer, such as the Home Office, National Document Fraud Unit or Centre for the Protection of National Infrastructure (CPNI)
- refresh their training at least every 3 years

If the evidence is being checked by a system, it must:

- have been built following good practice, such as the Home Office's guidance on identification document validation technology
- update the templates it checks the evidence against at least every 3 years

Confirm the UV or IR security features are genuine

The person or system doing the check will need to use a UV or IR light to make sure:

- the paper the evidence is printed on looks the way it should
- the alignment of the evidence looks the way it should
- any fluorescent features (such as fluorescent inks or fibres) look the way they should
- the evidence has not been tampered with (for example a UV light will show where UV features have been covered by glue if something has been stuck on the evidence)

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- holograms and positioning
- the way it's been laminated
- designs printed with optical variable ink (and check they look the way they should at certain angles)
- the format of any 'compound identifiers', such as a DVLA driver number or an MRZ
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Some places where you can find official templates are:

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- the EU and EEA driving licence handbook
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- have been built following good practice, such as the Home Office's guidance on identification document validation technology
- update the templates it checks the evidence against at least every 3 years

Score 3

The evidence will have a score of 3 if you do all of the following:

- confirm the evidence is valid or check the evidence has not been cancelled, lost or stolen
- confirm the visible security features are genuine
- confirm the UV or IR security features are genuine
- check the evidence has not expired

Alternatively, you can check the cryptographic security features are genuine.

Confirm the evidence is valid

The person or system will need to do the same checks to confirm the evidence is valid that are needed at score 2.

Check the evidence has not been cancelled, lost or stolen

The person or system doing the check will need to make sure the evidence has not been:

- cancelled by the organisation that issued it
- reported as lost or stolen

They can do this by checking an authoritative database of cancelled evidence, for example, Interpol for passports or a mobile phone operator for mobile phone contracts.

Confirm the visible security features are genuine

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 2 to confirm the visible security features are genuine.

They'll also need to:

- use evidence that has not been intercepted and reused (known as a 'replay attack')
- make sure any shadows or glare do not stop the security features on the evidence from being examined
- update any official templates that are used (such as those from PRADO) every year
- refresh their training in how to detect false documents every year (if the checks are being done by a person)

They must also confirm:

- designs printed using intaglio (raised) ink look the way they should
- designs that have been laser-etched look the way they should
- features are consistent and correct across sections of the evidence

Example

In a UK passport, there should be a passport number on the page with the person's details on it. You should check if this number is the same as the number punched on the other pages in the passport.

To check this, they must use one of the following:

- a magnification tool (such as a magnifier)
- other inspection equipment used to identify forged or counterfeit documents

Confirm the UV or IR security features are genuine

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 2 to confirm any UV or IR security features are genuine.

They'll also need to:

- use evidence that has not been intercepted and reused (known as a 'replay attack')
- make sure any shadows or glare do not stop the security features on the evidence from being examined
- update any official templates that are used every year
- refresh their training in how to detect false documents every year (if the checks are being done by a person)

Confirm the cryptographic security features are genuine

To make sure the cryptographic security features are genuine, the system that checks the evidence will need to:

- read the cryptographically protected information
- provide any required cryptographic keys
- check the evidence has not expired
- check the digital signature is correct

It will also need to check the signing key:

- belongs to the organisation that issued the evidence
- is the correct type for that evidence
- has not been revoked

Example

Most debit or credit cards will have a cryptographic chip on them. You can check the chip is genuine by asking a user to make a zero balance payment using a card reader. If the transaction is successful you'll know the cryptographic chip and the bank account linked to it are genuine.

Score 4

The evidence will have a score of 4 if you do all of the following:

- confirm the visible security features are genuine
- confirm the UV or IR security features are genuine
- confirm the cryptographic security features on the evidence are genuine
- check the evidence has not been cancelled, lost or stolen
- check the evidence has not expired

Confirm the visible security features are genuine

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 3 to confirm the visible security features are genuine.

They'll also need to:

- be supervised when they capture and examine the evidence by someone who's also been trained by a specialist trainer, such as the Home Office, National Document Fraud Unit or CPNI
- examine the evidence under 'controlled' light conditions (which means the lighting in the room creates the best possible environment for examining the security features on the evidence)
- examine the evidence under 'controlled' security conditions (which means there are ways to prevent systems from being fooled or people from being manipulated)

They'll need to check the following features of the evidence look correct:

- watermarks
- security fibres
- consistency throughout the piece of evidence
- secondary background ('ghost') images

Example

In the latest UK passport, there should be a ghost image of the person on the 'observations' page. You should check if the surname and date of birth in the image are the same as the person's details.

To check this, they must use one of the following:

- a magnification tool (such as a magnifier)
- a low angle ('oblique') light
- other inspection equipment to identify forged or counterfeit documents

Confirm the UV or IR security features are genuine

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 3 to confirm any UV or IR security features are genuine.

Confirm the cryptographic security features are genuine

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 3 to confirm the cryptographic security features are genuine.

Check the evidence has not been cancelled, lost or stolen

The person or system must do the same things needed at score 3 to confirm the evidence has not been cancelled, lost or stolen.

Check the claimed identity has existed over time

To lower the risk of you accepting a synthetic identity or an identity that belongs to someone who's died, you can check the claimed identity has existed over time.

This is also known as an 'activity' check.

You do not need to do this part of the identity checking process to meet all the identity profiles.

The highest score you can get for this part of the identity checking process is 4.

You should check if the claimed identity has interacted with other organisations. Some examples of interactions are:

- credit card transactions
- student loan repayments
- mortgage payments
- gas or electricity account payments
- when someone signs in to an online bank or retail account

You can also check if the claimed identity has records that show it's been known by organisations over time. Some examples of these records are:

- health records
- employment records
- school records

How confident you can be that the claimed identity was involved in an interaction depends on if:

- the organisation the claimed identity interacted with checked their identity
- the claimed identity's interactions are what you'd expect them to be

You should expect some people's interactions to appear differently to others. What interactions you expect a claimed identity to have usually depends on the type of interaction they're doing and the type of person they are (like their age or financial situation).

Example

You can expect someone who's been working for 20 years to have things like frequent financial transactions, but someone who's recently left school might not.

If you can't find interactions that happen in a way you'd expect for the claimed identity, you should find more interactions over a longer period of time.

Score 1

You'll get a score of 1 if you:

- have evidence of interactions between the claimed identity and an organisation
- know the organisation checked the claimed identity is who they say they are

These interactions need to have happened:

- over the last year
- in a way that you'd expect the claimed identity to behave

Example

Over the last year, you've seen posts on a social media website that you'd expect the owner of the account to make. This account appears to be linked to the claimed identity, but you cannot be sure they actually created it. This is because this social media website does not check users' identities when they sign up. However, you've used an authoritative source to make sure the email address or phone number associated with the account is linked to the claimed identity.

If the interactions do not happen in a way you'd expect the claimed identity to behave, you'll need to find interactions from over the last 3 years instead.

Score 2

You'll get a score of 2 if you:

- have evidence of interactions between the claimed identity and an organisation
- know the organisation used an authoritative source to check the claimed identity was who they said they were

These interactions need to have happened:

- over the last 6 months
- in a way that you'd expect the claimed identity to behave

Example

Over the last 6 months, you've seen payments to a post-pay electricity account that you'd expect the owner of the account to make. This electricity supplier checked the account owner's identity using a credit check. This means you know the claimed identity is linked to this account. You've found evidence of these payments by looking at printed or online statements that you know belong to the claimed identity.

If the interactions do not happen in a way you'd expect the claimed identity to behave, you'll need

to find interactions from over the last year instead.

Score 3

You'll get a score of 3 if you:

- have evidence of interactions between the claimed identity and an organisation
- know the organisation checked the claimed identity was who they said they were in a way that at least met the requirements of the Money Laundering Regulations 2017.

These interactions need to have happened:

- over the last 3 months
- in a way that you'd expect the claimed identity to behave

Example

Over the last 3 months, you've seen mortgage payments that you'd expect the mortgage owner to make. The mortgage provider checked the mortgage owner's identity when they applied for it in a way that follows the Money Laundering Regulations 2017.

You've found evidence of these payments by looking at printed or online statements that you know belong to the claimed identity.

If the interactions do not happen in a way you'd expect the claimed identity to behave, you'll need to find interactions from over the last 6 months instead.

Score 4

You'll get a score of 4 if you:

- have evidence of interactions between the claimed identity and an organisation
- know the organisation checked the claimed identity was who they said they were in a way that at least met the requirements of the Money Laundering Regulations 2017
- know the organisation compared the claimed identity to an image from an authoritative source

You'll need to find at least one interaction from the last 3 months.

Example

You've seen that the claimed identity has been on an international flight in the last 3 months. You know their identity was checked when they crossed the border. They would've shown their passport to a border officer, who would've checked it was genuine. The border officer would also have checked the person matched the photo on their passport.

Check if the claimed identity is at high risk of identity fraud

You should make sure the claimed identity is not at a higher than usual risk of identity fraud or likely to be synthetic.

You can do this by checking the details of the claimed identity with authoritative counter-fraud data sources, such as a national fraud database.

This is also known as an 'identity fraud' check.

The highest score you can get for this part of the identity checking process is 3.

Score 1

You'll get a score of 1 if you use an authoritative source to check if the claimed identity has either:

- had its details stolen (even if those details have not been used fraudulently yet)
- been reported as stolen
- If either of these things have happened, you must do extra verification checks.

You must also use an authoritative source to check if the claimed identity is a known synthetic identity.

If it is, you must reduce these risks by:

- doing additional verification checks
- collecting more evidence of the claimed identity

Score 2

To get a score of 2 you must do all the checks needed to get a score of 1. You must also use an authoritative source to check that the claimed identity:

- belongs to someone who's still alive
- is known by an organisation that should have a record of that person (for example an Electoral Registration Office in a local authority)
- is at a usual risk of being impersonated (for example, a 'politically exposed person' like a politician or judge is at a higher than usual risk of being impersonated)

You must do extra 'verification' checks if you get any information from the authoritative body that suggests these things are not true.

Score 3

You'll get a score of 3 if you use more than one authoritative source to do all the checks needed to get a score of 2.

The sources must also be 'independent', which means they're either:

- separate from the part of your organisation that checks the person's identity
- part of a different organisation

Check that the identity belongs to the person who's claiming it

You must prove that the person who's going through your identity checking process is the claimed identity. You might let someone access your service using a claimed identity that belongs to someone else if you do not do this.

This is also known as a 'verification' check.

The highest score you can get for this part of the identity checking process is 4.

Score 1

The person will get a score of 1 if they can give you information that does not change over time ('static' information) that only the claimed identity should know.

You should check this by asking the person to answer questions or complete tasks. These are known as 'knowledge-based verification' (KBV) challenges.

Example

You can ask the person to give you a customer reference number that was issued to them when they bought something from your organisation. You can make sure the number was issued to their claimed identity by checking it against your records. This reference number is static because it does not change over time.

How many KBV challenges you ask the person to do depends on if they're low, medium or high quality.

You should ask the person to do one of the following:

- 2 low-quality KBV challenges
- 4 low-quality multiple-choice KBV challenges
- 1 medium quality KBV challenge
- 2 medium quality multiple-choice KBV challenges
- 1 high-quality KBV challenge

Quality rules for KBV challenges

KBV challenges should be specific enough to be able to prove that that person is who they say they are.

Someone who has stolen a claimed identity's wallet, purse or phone should not be able to complete all of the KBV challenges you ask them to do.

Low-quality KBV challenges must be:

- about the claimed identity
- clear and simple so the person knows exactly what you're asking them
- about something the claimed identity can reasonably be expected to know
- from a source that maintains the integrity of the information the question is based on
- from a source that makes sure the information cannot be misused by the claimed identity (for example the claimed identity should not be able to create false records)

Low-quality KBV challenges must not:

- be able to be answered with information that's available in the public domain (for example in an open dataset or on a website that anyone can access)
- be able to be answered using information the person has submitted at another point in the identity checking process
- be predictable (the questions and answers should change each time someone goes through your identity-checking process)
- have answers that can be easily guessed if you're asking multiple-choice questions
- include information that will give the person the answer to another question
- show personal information (unless the person has already submitted that at another point in the identity checking process)

Medium quality KBV challenges must meet all the requirements for low-quality challenges, as well as:

- be based on information from a source that did its own identity checks on the claimed identity
- share codes, like a one-time password sent to the claimed identity's phone, in a way that means you can be sure they were given to the claimed identity (if you use them)

High-quality KBV challenges must meet all the requirements for low and medium quality challenges. They must also be based on information:

- from a source that checked the claimed identity was who they said they were in a way that follows the Money Laundering Regulations 2017
- from a source that makes sure the information cannot be accessed, modified or created by its employees
- from a source that's separate from your organisation
- from a source that's regulated by a statutory or independent body
- that cannot be known or accessed by anyone apart from the claimed identity and their immediate family without breaking the law (for example you should not use information that you know is available on the dark web)

Score 2

The person will get a score of 2 if you do one of the following:

- make sure the person physically matches the photo on or associated with the strongest piece of genuine evidence you have of the claimed identity (you can do this in person or remotely)
- make sure the person's biometric information (such as their face or fingerprints) matches biometric information from (or associated with) the strongest piece of genuine evidence you have of the claimed identity
- ask the person to complete multiple 'dynamic' KBV challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

Make sure someone matches the photo in person

The person doing the match must have:

- been trained in how to detect impostors
- good enough eyesight (with or without prescription lenses) to effectively compare the person to the image

When doing the match, you must make sure:

- the person whose identity is being checked is present
- the light conditions are good enough to clearly see the person and the image on the evidence (for example there should be no glare or shadows)
- you are comparing the person to a photo from a genuine piece of evidence
- the photo has not been tampered with

The person whose identity is being checked must not:

- be wearing a head covering (unless it's for religious or medical reasons)
- have their eyes closed
- have anything covering their face or eyes (such as shadows or their hair)

Make sure someone matches the photo remotely

When doing the match, you must make sure:

- the person whose identity is being checked is present when their image or video is captured (you should not use a scan or an upload from a photo or video feed)
- the image or video has not been intercepted and reused ('replayed')
- you are comparing an image or video of the person to an image or video of a genuine piece of evidence
- the image or video has been shared in a way that prevents it from being tampered with (for example by using a 'man-in-the-middle' attack)

If a person is doing the match, they must have:

- been trained in how to detect impostors

- good enough eyesight (with or without prescription lenses) to effectively compare the person to the image

The image or video of the person must be:

- clear and in focus
- in colour

In the image or video, the person must:

- be in clear contrast to the background
- not have 'red eye'
- not wear a head covering (unless it's for religious or medical reasons)
- not have their eyes closed
- not have anything covering their face or eyes (such as shadows or their hair)

Make sure someone matches biometric information

When doing the biometric comparison, you must make sure:

- the number of 'false matches' and 'false non-matches' in your system are appropriate for your security and usability needs
- your system matches the person to biometric information that's known to belong to the claimed identity (this is known as 'one-to-one verification')
- the biometric information has not been tampered with (if it was taken from a piece of evidence)
- your system can identify if the person's biometric information has been intercepted and reused ('replayed')
- the biometric information has been shared in a way that prevents it from being tampered with
- your system can tell if someone's using an artefact to convince the system they're someone else (known as 'spoofing') - this could mean making sure they're not holding up a photo or playing a recording of someone's else's voice if you're checking a facial or vocal type ('modality') of biometric
- your system confirms that the person is real (known as a 'liveness' test)

Example

If you're checking a fingerprint biometric modality, you can use heart rate sensors to make sure that the person who is providing their fingerprint is alive.

Asking the person to complete dynamic KBV challenges

To be 'dynamic', the answers to a KBV challenge must change over time. This will make it harder for impostors using information from things like data breaches to successfully complete the challenge.

The KBV challenges must follow the same quality rules that need to be followed to get a score of 1.

The KBV challenges must also not be based on information from a single source. An account and a mortgage from the same bank count as different sources if the claimed identity went through a different application process to get each one.

Example

You can make a zero balance transaction into the claimed identity's bank account and attach a reference number (which is valid for a short period of time) to it. This will show up as a code on the claimed identity's bank statement.

The person will need to sign in to the claimed identity's account within the allowed time to get the code. If they give you the correct code, it will prove the person you're dealing with has control of and access to that account. Only the claimed identity should be able to do this.

How many KBV challenges you ask the person to complete depends on the quality of the questions. You should ask them to complete one of the following:

- 4 low-quality KBV challenges
- 8 low-quality multiple-choice KBV challenges
- 2 medium quality KBV challenges
- 3 medium quality multiple-choice KBV challenges
- 2 high-quality KBV challenges
- 2 high-quality multiple-choice KBV challenges

Score 3

The person will get a score of 3 if you do either of the following in-person or remotely:

- make sure they physically match the photo on (or associated with) the strongest piece of genuine evidence you have of the claimed identity
- make sure their biometric information matches biometric information from (or associated with) the strongest piece of genuine evidence you have of the claimed identity

Make sure someone matches a photo in person or remotely

The person doing the match must have all the skills and training needed to get a score of 2. They must refresh their training in how to detect impostors every year.

The person or system doing the match must do everything needed to check someone matches a photo (in person or remotely) at score 2. You must also make sure:

- your process has a way to identify if someone is wearing a mask, makeup or prosthetics to look like someone else
- their eyes are visible without any glare or reflections (if the person is wearing glasses)

Make sure someone matches biometric information

The system doing the match must do everything needed to check someone matches biometric information at score 2. You must also make sure:

- the number of 'false matches' and 'false non-matches' in your system are appropriate for your security and usability needs and are based on industry best practice (for example ISO/IEC TR 29156:2015)
- your system uses a biometric algorithm that's been proven to be effective against a recognised benchmark, like the National Institute of Standards and Technology's (NIST's) face recognition vendor test guidance
- the person's biometric information is captured under conditions that do not reduce the accuracy of the type of biometric check being used (things like light, noise, and humidity impact the success rates for different biometric modalities and should be adjusted if needed)
- your system can tell when someone is spoofing the system using an artefact that's taken time, money and effort to create, for example, detecting if someone is changing the pitch and adding background noise to a recording of a vocal biometric
- your system uses multiple processes or measures to confirm that the person is real (known as an enhanced 'liveness' test)

Example

If you're checking a facial biometric modality, you can ask the person to take a short video of themselves, during which they repeat a random sequence of words back to you. This helps you make sure there's a real person involved. You can also continually assess small movements of the person's head while the biometric measurement is taking place.

Score 4

The person will get a score of 4 if you make sure their biometric information matches biometric information from (or associated with) the strongest piece of genuine evidence you have.

The system doing the match must do everything needed to check someone matches biometric information at score 3.

It must also be able to identify when someone is spoofing the system using a sophisticated artefact that's taken a lot of time, money, effort or criminal activity to create. If you're checking a facial biometric modality, this could mean making sure the person is not showing a 3D animated avatar on a hijacked computer or device.

The biometric information on the evidence and the biometric information of the person must also be captured under 'controlled conditions'. This means:

- any equipment has been designed in a way that makes it difficult to be tampered with
- someone who was trained in how to compare people to their identity evidence by a specialist trainer (such as the Home Office, National Document Fraud Unit or

CPNI) supervises how the biometric information is captured

- the supervisor refreshes their training every year
- the supervisor monitors the behaviour of the person whose biometric information is being captured to make sure it's not suspicious
- the area and equipment used to capture the biometric information has been designed in a way that reduces the likelihood of incorrect matches for the type of biometric information being used

Example

Some facial recognition software will be less accurate in different light conditions. A facial biometric comparison should take place under the best light conditions for the biometric algorithm that's being used. This will reduce incorrect matches and false rejections. The area where the check is being done should also be monitored by trained personnel who make sure people are not trying to fool the system.

Identity profiles

Each part of the identity checking process will protect you or your service against different identity risks.

There are a number of ways to combine parts of the identity checking process to meet a level of confidence in an identity. These combinations are known as identity profiles.

Each identity profile will give you one of the following levels of confidence:

- low confidence
- medium confidence
- high confidence
- very high confidence

You can only meet a level of confidence if you meet an identity profile. The higher the level of confidence an identity profile meets, the more protection you or your service will have.

An identity profile is made up of scores for each part of the identity checking process. Your scores must be the same as, or higher than, the scores in each part to meet the profile. Do not add your scores up.

Example

You need a validity score of 1 to meet an identity profile. The evidence from the person whose identity you're checking has a validity score of 2. You can use this score of 2 to meet the lower score requirements of the identity profile.

You can choose to meet any identity profile. The identity profile you choose might depend on:

- how confident you need to be in someone's identity
- what evidence your users are likely to have
- which parts of the identity checking process you can do
- how thoroughly you do each part of the identity checking process
- how many pieces of evidence you need

Meeting an identity profile and reaching a level of confidence will mean:

- you know how well your service is protected against identity risks
- your identity-checking process can be understood and reused by other organisations or services

If you collect evidence from a user that does not include all the personal information you need, you will need to collect other evidence that does. You'll also need to link these pieces of evidence together to make sure they all relate to the claimed identity.

Example

You need evidence of a person's name and address. A person gives you a bus pass that shows their photo and address but not their name. They also give you a genuine passport that shows their photo and their name. You check these photos match, so you know both pieces of evidence relate to the same claimed identity.

If you collect more than one piece of evidence, you must make sure the evidence has been issued by either:

- different organisations
- an organisation that used a different identity checking process to issue each piece of evidence you're using

Example

You collect 3 pieces of evidence of a claimed identity from different organisations. One is a letter from a local authority, one is from a solicitor and one is from a gas company. They were all issued to the same claimed identity.

Low confidence in the person's identity

Compared to not doing any identity checks, having low confidence in the person's identity will lower the risk of you accepting either:

- synthetic identities
- impostors who are not close friends or family of the identity they're pretending to be

If you have 1 piece of evidence

There are 3 identity profiles you can meet if you collect 1 piece of evidence.

Low confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile A (L1A)

Check	Score
Strength	2
Validity	2
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	2
Verification	1

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- know that evidence of the claimed identity exists
- know if the evidence is genuine or valid
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person going through the identity checking process knows things that only the claimed identity should know

You do not need to do an activity check because you know the organisation that issued the evidence already did basic checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

Low confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile B (L1B)

Check	Score
Strength	3
Validity	2
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	Not needed
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- know that strong evidence of the claimed identity exists
- know if the evidence is genuine or valid
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

You do not need to do:

- an activity check because the organisation that issued the evidence did multiple checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world
- an identity fraud check because the person going through the identity checking process has been matched to the claimed identity through a physical or biometric comparison

Low confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile C (L1C)

Check	Score
Strength	3
Validity	3
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	1
Verification	2

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- know that strong evidence of the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- have checked the person going through the identity checking process matches the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence, or know they can complete challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

You do not need to do an activity check because you know the organisation that issued the evidence already did multiple checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

If you have 3 pieces of evidence

There's only one identity profile you can meet if you collect 3 pieces of evidence.

Low confidence, 3 pieces of evidence, profile A (L3A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)	Score (third piece of evidence)
Strength	1	1	1
Validity	1	1	1

Check	Score
Activity	3
Identity fraud	2
Verification	2

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- know each piece of evidence appears to be genuine
- be confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- have checked the person going through the identity checking process matches the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence, or know they can complete challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

You'll need to collect multiple pieces of evidence because the evidence you have does not have many security features that stop it being forged or counterfeit.

Medium confidence in the person's identity

Compared to low confidence, having medium confidence in the person's identity will lower the risk of you:

- accepting synthetic identities

- accepting impostors who are not close friends or family of the identity they're pretending to be
- accepting impostors who do not look like the identity they're pretending to be

Medium confidence also provides some protection against accepting impostors who are close friends or family of the identity they're pretending to be.

If you have 1 piece of evidence

There are 2 identity profiles you can meet if you collect 1 piece of evidence.

Medium confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile A (M1A)

Check	Score
Strength	4
Validity	3
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	1
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- know that very strong evidence of the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have checked the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person going through the identity checking process matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

You do not need to do an activity check because you know the organisation that issued the evidence already did multiple checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

Medium confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile B (M1B)

Check	Score
Strength	3
Validity	3
Activity	2
Identity fraud	1
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have records that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person going through the identity checking process matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

If you have 2 pieces of evidence

There are 4 identity profiles you can meet if you collect 2 pieces of evidence.

Medium confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile A (M2A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	2	2
Validity	2	2

Check	Score
Activity	3
Identity fraud	1
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have more than one piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine or valid
- be confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person going through the identity checking process matches either the photo or biometric information on the evidence

Medium confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile B (M2B)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	3	2
Validity	3	2

Check	Score
Activity	2
Identity fraud	2
Verification	2

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine, valid or both
- have records that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- have checked the person going through the identity checking process matches the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence, or know they can complete challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

Medium confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile C (M2C)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	3	2
Validity	3	2

Check	Score
Activity	1
Identity fraud	1
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine, valid or both
- have checked the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity

- be confident the person going through the identity checking process matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

Medium confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile D (M2D)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	4	2
Validity	3	2

Check	Score
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	2
Verification	2

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine, valid or both
- have checked the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- have checked the person going through the identity checking process matches the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence, or know they can complete challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

You do not need to do an activity check because you know the organisation that issued the evidence already did multiple checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

If you have 3 pieces of evidence

There's only one identity profile you can meet if you collect 3 pieces of evidence.

Medium confidence, 3 pieces of evidence, profile A (M3A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)	Score (third piece of evidence)
Strength	2	2	2
Validity	2	2	2

Check	Score
Activity	2
Identity fraud	2
Verification	2

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have multiple pieces of evidence that show the claimed identity exists
- know each piece of evidence is genuine or valid
- have records that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- have checked the person going through the identity checking process matches the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence, or know they can complete challenges that only the claimed identity should be able to do

High confidence in the person's identity

Compared to medium confidence, having high confidence in the person's identity will lower the risk of you:

- accepting synthetic identities
- accepting impostors who know the identity (including close friends or family)
- accepting impostors who do not know the identity
- being targeted by people who do not look like the identity

If you have 1 piece of evidence

There are 2 identity profiles you can meet if the person gives you 1 piece of evidence.

High confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile A (H1A)

Check	Score
Strength	4
Validity	3
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	3
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have made sure you or your service has reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

You do not need to do an activity check because you know the organisation that issued the evidence did multiple thorough checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

High confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile B (H1B)

Check	Score
Strength	4
Validity	4
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	Not needed
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

You do not need to do:

- an identity fraud check as the person going through the identity checking process is unlikely to be someone else (you'll know this because they've been matched to the claimed identity through a physical or biometric comparison)
- an activity check because the organisation that issued the evidence did multiple thorough checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world

If you have 2 pieces of evidence

There are 3 identity profiles you can meet if you collect 2 pieces of evidence.

High confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile A (H2A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	3	3
Validity	3	3

Check	Score
Activity	3
Identity fraud	2
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have more than one piece of strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists know both pieces of evidence are genuine and valid
- be confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

High confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile B (H2B)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	4	3
Validity	3	3

Check	Score
Activity	Not needed
Identity fraud	2
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know both pieces of evidence are genuine and valid
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

You will not need to do an activity check because the organisation that issued the evidence did multiple thorough checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world.

High confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile C (H2C)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	4	2
Validity	3	2
Check		Score
Activity		2
Identity fraud		2
Verification		3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine, valid or both
- be confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

If you have 3 pieces of evidence

There's only one identity profile you can meet if you collect 3 pieces of evidence.

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)	Score (third piece of evidence)
Strength	3	2	2
Validity	3	2	2

Check	Score
Activity	3
Identity fraud	3
Verification	3

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have more than one other piece of evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine, valid or both
- be confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person matches either the photo or biometric information that's shown on the evidence

Very high confidence in the person's identity

Very high confidence makes it very difficult for someone to:

- use a synthetic identity
- impersonate someone without breaking the law

If you have 1 piece of evidence

There's only one identity profile you can meet if you collect 1 piece of evidence.

Very high confidence, 1 piece of evidence, profile A (V1A)

Check	Score
Strength	4
Validity	4
Check	Score
Activity	4
Identity fraud	3
Verification	4

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- be very confident that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person's biometric information matches what's shown on the evidence

You'll have been as thorough as possible with all parts of the identity checking process so you only need one piece of evidence.

If you have 2 pieces of evidence

There are 2 identity profiles you can meet if you collect 2 pieces of evidence.

Very high confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile A (V2A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	4	4
Validity	4	4
Check	Score	
Activity	Not needed	
Identity fraud	2	
Verification	4	

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have more than one piece of very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person's biometric information matches what's shown on the evidence

This means the organisation that issued the evidence did multiple thorough checks to make sure the claimed identity exists in the real world (so you do not need to do an activity check).

Very high confidence, 2 pieces of evidence, profile B (V2B)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)
Strength	4	3
Validity	4	3

Check	Score
Activity	2
Identity fraud	3
Verification	4

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have another piece of strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have records that the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person's biometric information matches what's shown on the evidence

If you have 3 pieces of evidence

There's only one identity profile you can meet if you have 3 pieces of evidence.

Very high confidence, 3 pieces of evidence, profile A (V3A)

Check	Score (first piece of evidence)	Score (second piece of evidence)	Score (third piece of evidence)
Strength	4	3	3
Validity	4	3	3
Check			Score
Activity			1
Identity fraud			2
Verification			4

By meeting this identity profile, you will:

- have very strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- have more than one other piece of strong evidence that shows the claimed identity exists
- know the evidence is genuine and valid
- have checked the claimed identity exists in the real world
- have made sure you or your service have reduced the risks of any known identity fraud associated with the claimed identity
- be confident the person's biometric information matches what's shown on the evidence

You can do weaker activity and identity fraud checks because you have multiple pieces of evidence that were issued by organisations that checked the claimed identity exists in the real world